THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Beginner

Read it like a storybook: one step on each page, a big picture, a few words, and one thing to try at the piano. After each room, a page to practise.

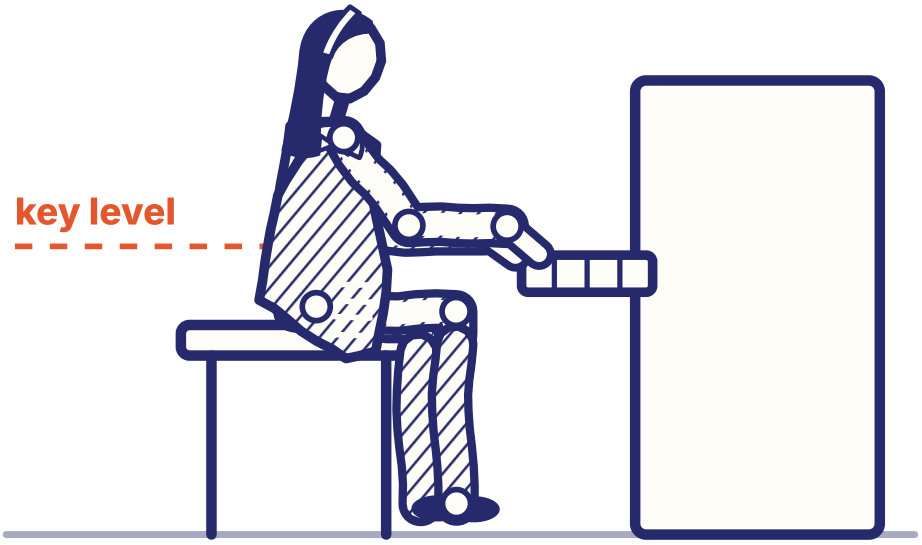
THE ROOMS

1 · Sitting and hands
2 · The keyboard
3 · Finger numbers
4 · The staff and the clefs
5 · The beat
6 · Notes: crotchet and minim
7 · Notes: three beats and four
8 · Loud and soft
9 · Ear training

ROOM 1 · STEP 1 OF 3

Sitting and hands

SCAN TO LISTEN



Sit tall on the front half of the stool, with both **feet flat** on the floor.

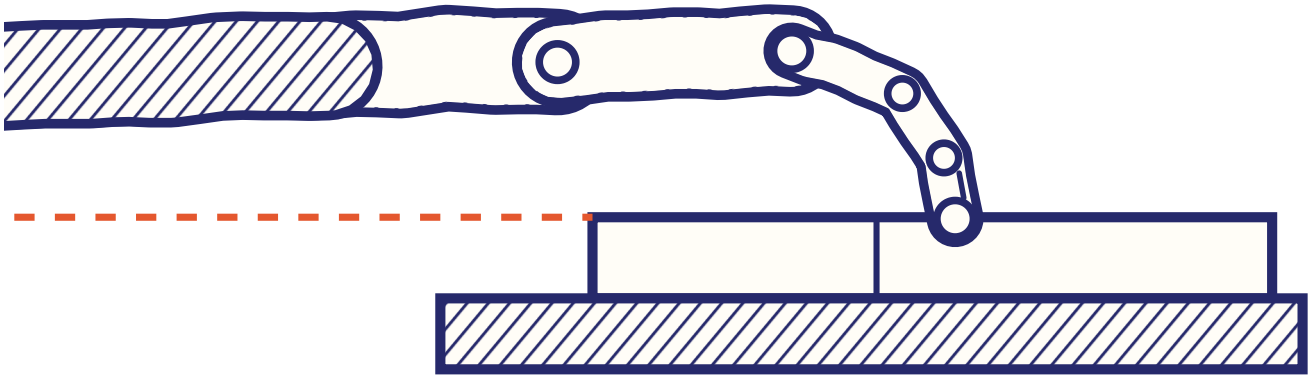
Your arms float out in front, **level with the keys**, like a table top.

Try it at the piano

1. Sit down. Lift your shoulders up to your ears, then let them drop.

ROOM 1 · STEP 2 OF 3

Sitting and hands



Hold a small ball in your hand. That **round shape** is your playing hand.

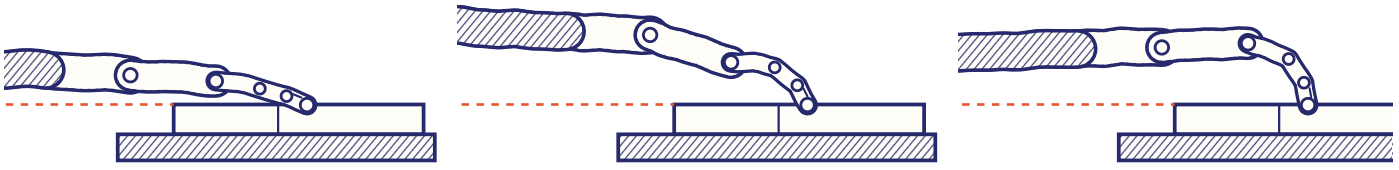
Your knuckles stand up like a **bridge**, and you play on your **fingertips**.

Try it at the piano

1. Hold a ball or an orange. Put your hand on the keys without changing its shape.

ROOM 1 · STEP 3 OF 3

Sitting and hands



× flat × fallen in ✓ round

A **flat** hand is fast asleep. A bridge that has **fallen in** cannot carry anything.

The **round** hand can play all day.

Try it at the piano

1. Make the flat hand, then the fallen bridge, then the round hand. Feel the difference.

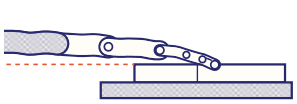
ROOM 1 · PRACTISE

Sitting and hands

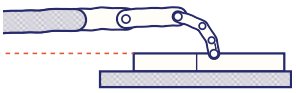
1 Flat, fallen in, or round?

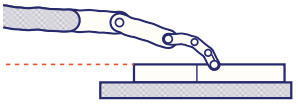
★☆☆

Write the word under each hand. The first is done.



flat





2 Too low, too high, or right?

★★☆

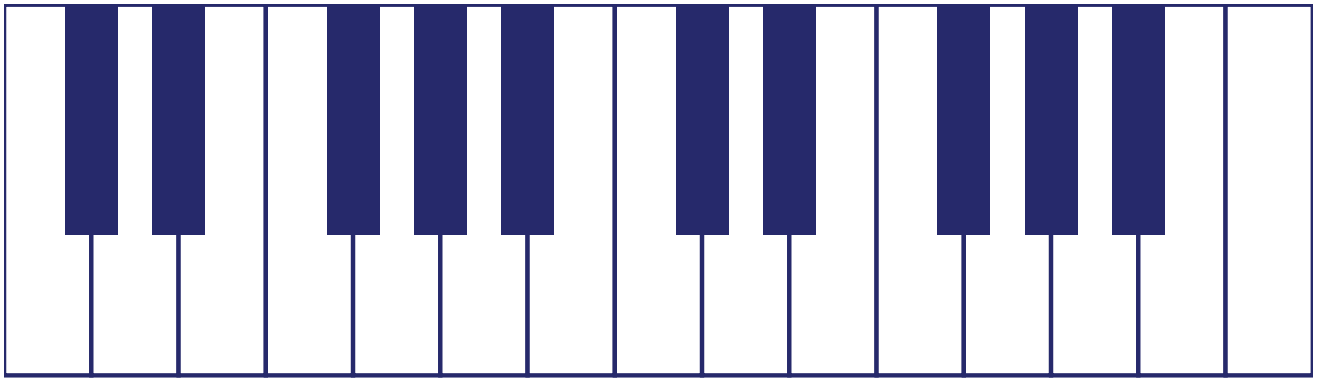
Write too low, too high or right.

WHAT YOU SEE	THE STOOL IS
The elbows are well below the keys; the forearms go uphill.	too low
The forearms are level with the keys.	
The elbows are above the keys; the wrists drop down to them.	

ROOM 2 · STEP 1 OF 3

The keyboard

SCAN TO LISTEN



Look at the black keys. They come in **twos** and **threes**, again and again, all the way along.

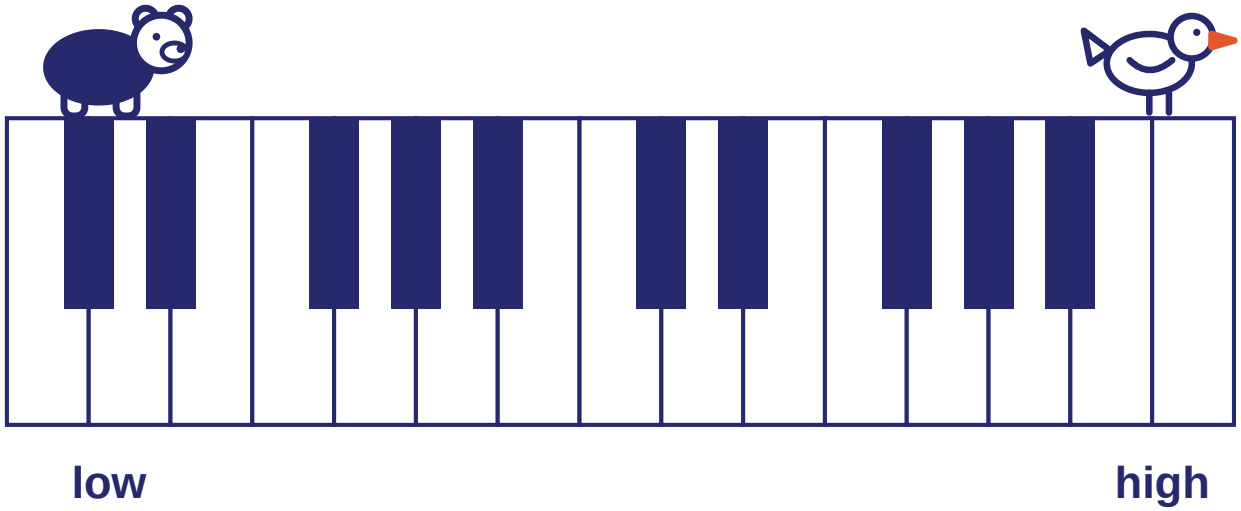
Find the pattern once and you can never get lost.

Try it at the piano

1. Touch every group of two black keys, from the left end to the right end. Then every group of three.

ROOM 2 · STEP 2 OF 3

The keyboard





Left is low, like a big grumpy bear. **Right is high**, like a little bird.

Go to the right and every key sounds a little higher.

Try it at the piano

1. Play the lowest key you can reach, then the highest. Bear, then bird.

ROOM 2 · STEP 3 OF 3

The keyboard



Every white key has a letter. Beside the **two** black keys live **C, D, E**. Beside the **three** live **F, G, A, B**.

After B comes C again: seven letters, round and round.

Try it at the piano

1. Find a group of two black keys. Play the three white keys around it and say C, D, E.

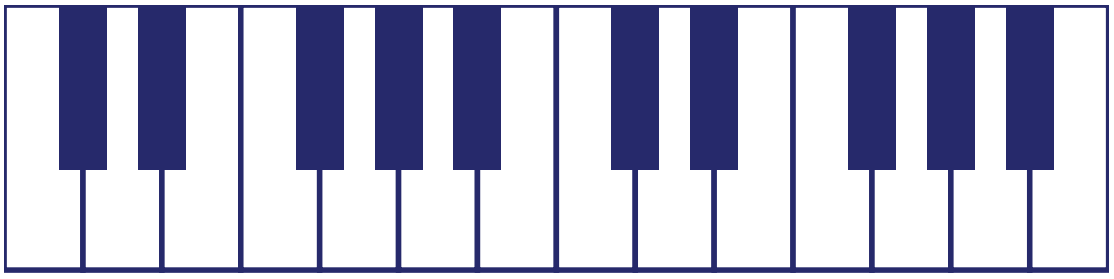
ROOM 2 · PRACTISE

The keyboard

1 Twos and threes

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Circle every group of two black keys. Draw a box round every group of three. How many of each?

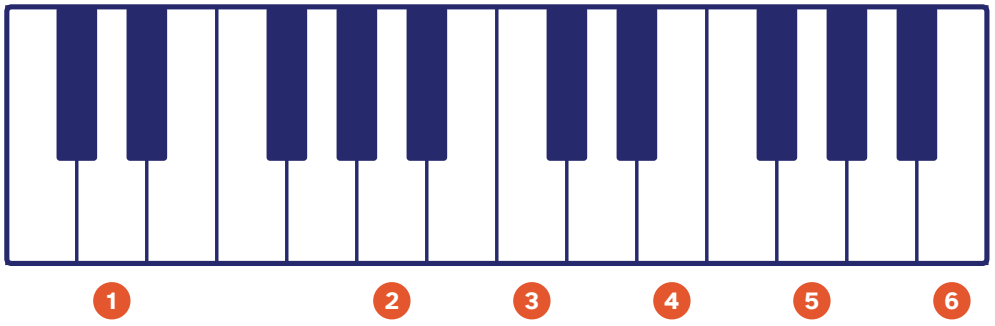


groups of two ☐ groups of three ☐

2 Name the keys

★☆☆

Find the black-key group next to each number. Write the letter of the numbered key. The first is done.

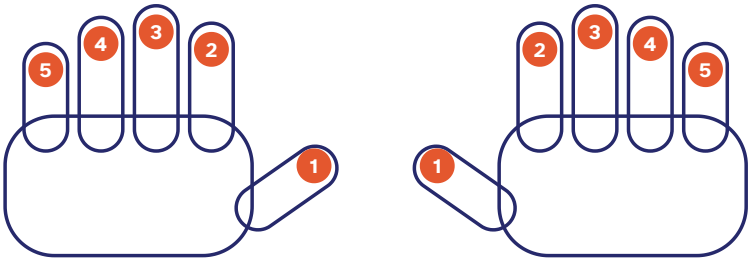


1 D 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐

ROOM 3 · STEP 1 OF 2

Finger numbers

SCAN TO LISTEN



Every finger has a **number**. The **thumb is 1**, then 2, 3, 4, and the little finger is **5**.

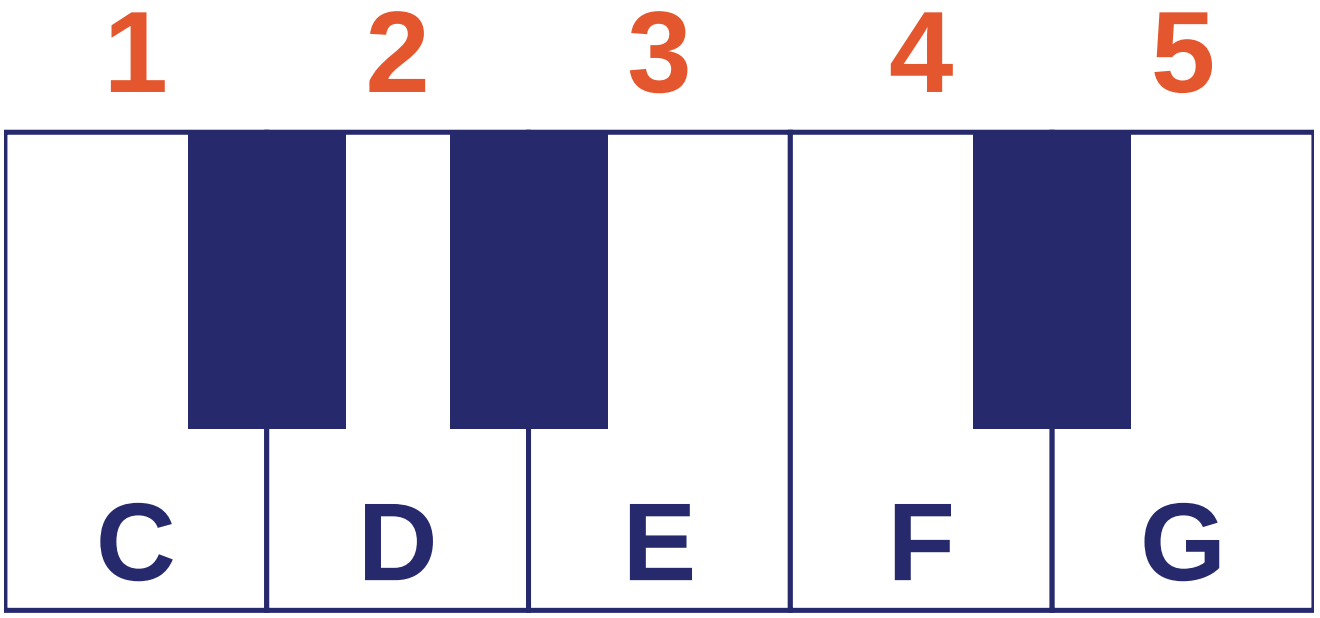
It is the same in both hands: thumbs are always 1.

Try it at the piano

1. Hold up both hands. Wiggle finger 1, then 2, 3, 4, 5, saying the numbers.

ROOM 3 · STEP 2 OF 2

Finger numbers



Find any **C**: the white key just left of two black keys. Put your right thumb on it. Now **C D E F G** are fingers **1 2 3 4 5**.

In the left hand the little finger starts: C D E F G are **5 4 3 2 1**.

Try it at the piano

1 Right thumb on C. Play C D E F G and back, saying the finger numbers. Then the left hand, starting with finger 5.

ROOM 3 · PRACTISE

Finger numbers

1 Finger numbers

★☆☆

Write the number of each finger. They are the same in both hands. The first is done.

FINGER	NUMBER	FINGER	NUMBER
thumb	1	ring finger	
index finger		little finger	
middle finger			

2 Which finger?

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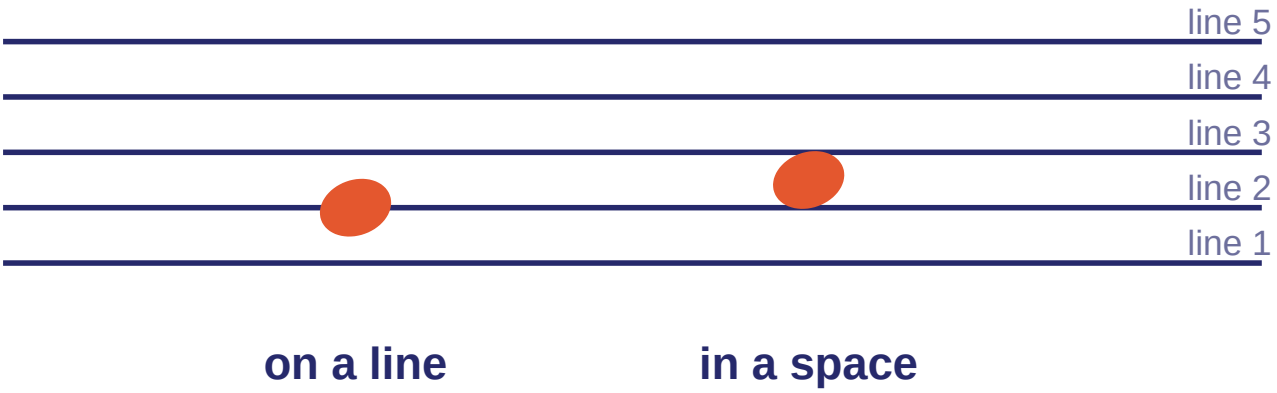
Right hand, thumb on C. Write the finger that plays each note. The first is done.

NOTE	E	G	D	F	C
Finger	3				

ROOM 4 · STEP 1 OF 2

The staff and the clefs

SCAN TO LISTEN



on a line **in a space**

Music is written on **five lines**, called the **staff**.

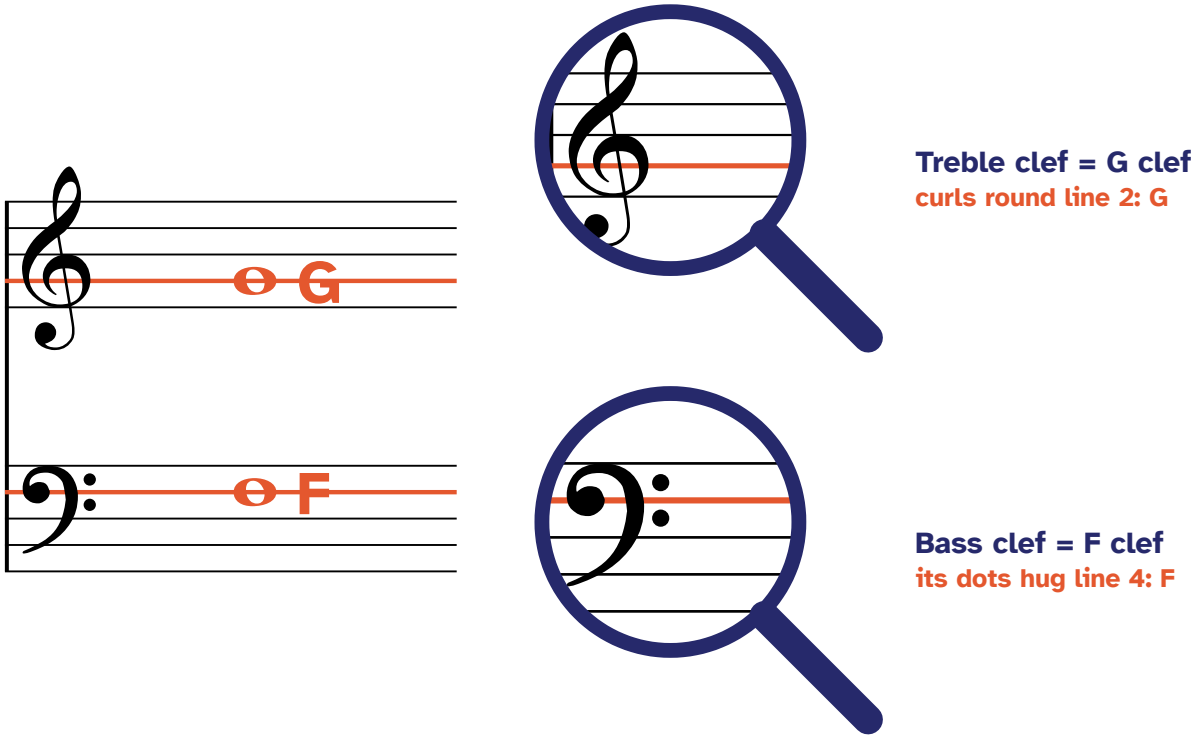
A note can sit **on a line**. Or it can sit **in a space**. Higher up means higher on the piano.

Try it at the piano

1. Count the lines from the bottom: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5. Then count the four spaces.

ROOM 4 · STEP 2 OF 2

The staff and the clefs



Treble clef = G clef
curls round line 2: G

Bass clef = F clef
its dots hug line 4: F

A **clef** at the start says which notes the lines stand for.

The **treble clef** is the Queen of the high notes: her curl wraps round the line for **G**. The **bass clef** is the King of the low notes: his two dots hug the line for **F**.

Try it at the piano

1. Play any high key with your right hand: the Queen's side. Then any low key with your left: the King's side.

ROOM 4 · PRACTISE

The staff and the clefs

1 The clefs

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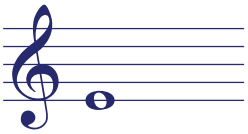
Write the name of each clef and the note it marks.

CLEF	NAME	IT MARKS THE LINE FOR
𝄞		
𝄢		

2 Line or space?

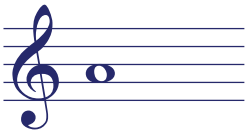
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Circle line or space, then write its number (counted from the bottom). The first is done.

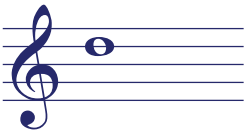


(line) · space

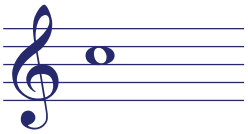
1



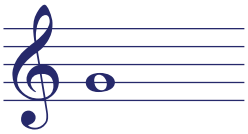
line · space



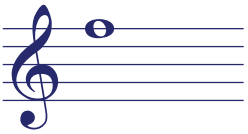
line · space



line · space



line · space

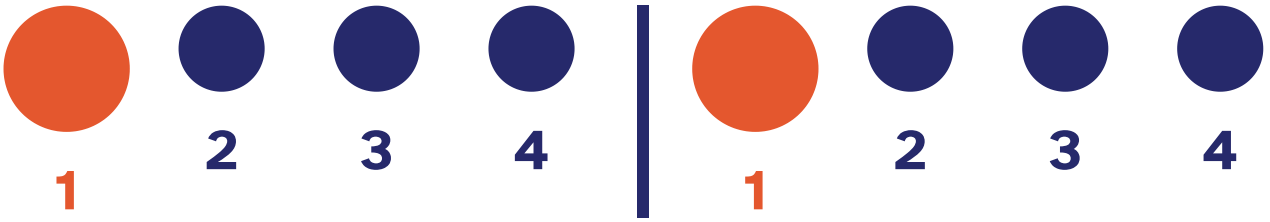


line · space

ROOM 5 · STEP 1 OF 2

The beat

SCAN TO LISTEN



Music has a steady **beat**, like a heartbeat. It never speeds up and never stops.

We count the beats: 1, 2, 3, 4, and round again.

Try it at the piano

1. Put a hand on your heart. Tap that steady beat on your knee and count 1 2 3 4.

ROOM 5 · STEP 2 OF 2

The beat





Bar lines put the beats into groups called **bars**. **Beat 1** of every bar is the strongest.

Sometimes a beat is **silent**. You still count it.

Try it at the piano

1. Clap three in a bar: STRONG, weak, weak. Then leave out one clap, but keep counting.

ROOM 5 · PRACTISE

The beat

1 How many beats in each bar?

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Count the dots between the bar lines. The first is done.



3







2 Add the bar lines

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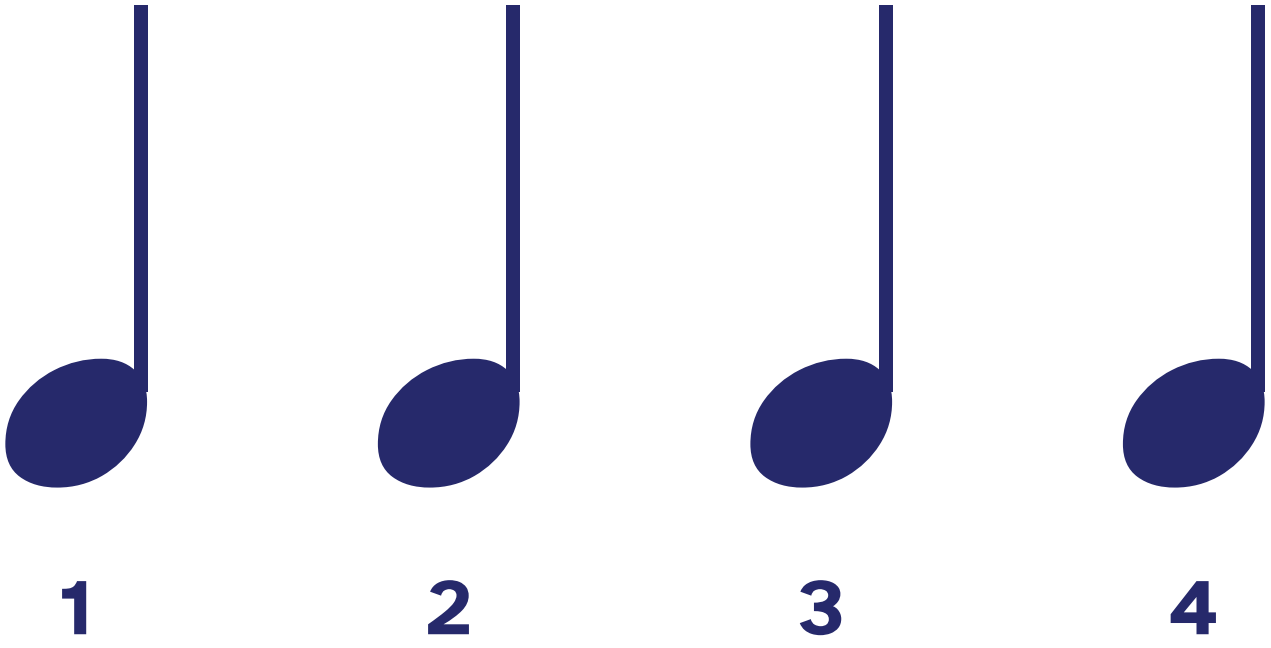
Beat 1 is the big coral dot. Draw a bar line just before each one (the first is done).



ROOM 6 · STEP 1 OF 3

Notes: crotchet and minim

SCAN TO LISTEN



This is a **crotchet**. It lasts **one beat**.

Four crotchets fill a bar of four: play, play, play, play.

Try it at the piano

1 Play C four times, one for each beat, counting 1 2 3 4.

ROOM 6 · STEP 2 OF 3

Notes: crotchet and minim



1 – 2 3 – 4

This is a **minim**. Its head is empty, and it lasts **two beats**.

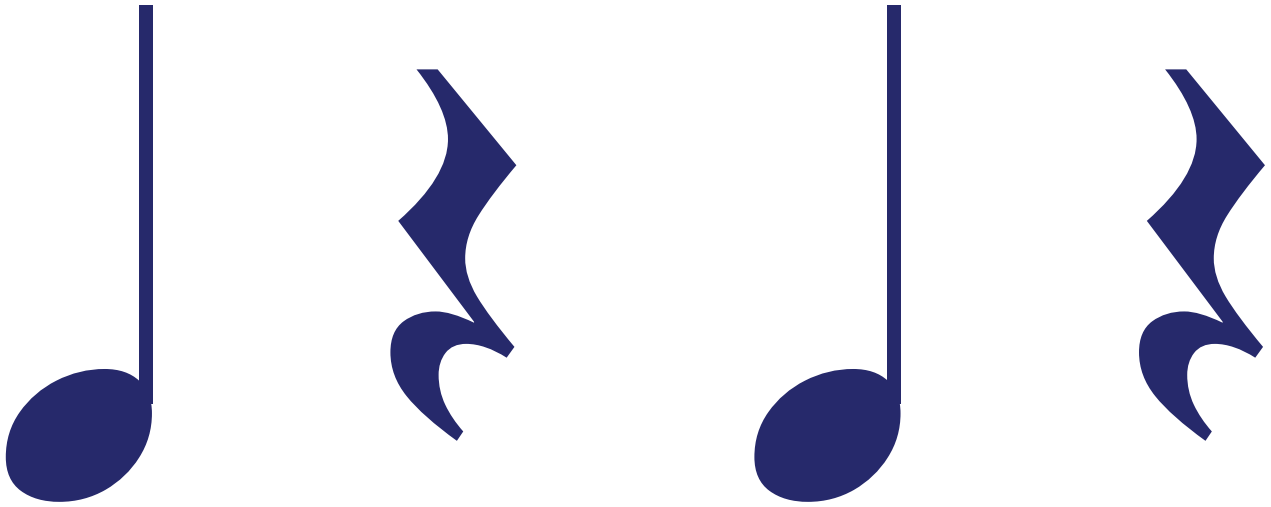
Play on the first beat and **hold** through the second.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C as a minim: press on 1, hold through 2. Then again on 3, holding through 4.

ROOM 6 · STEP 3 OF 3

Notes: crotchet and minim



play shh play shh

Silence has signs too, called **rests**. A **crotchet rest** is one beat of silence.

You count a rest just like a note. You just do not play.

Try it at the piano

1. Play, shh, play, shh: C on beats 1 and 3, silence on 2 and 4. Keep counting.

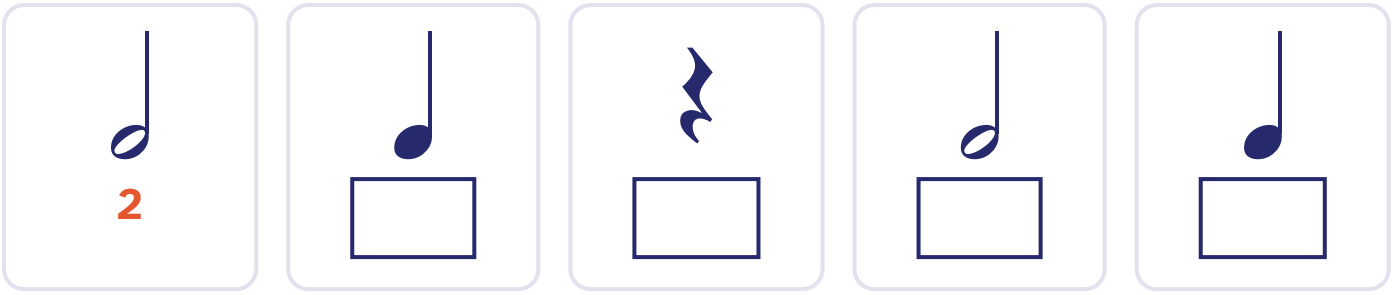
ROOM 6 · PRACTISE

Notes: crotchet and minim

1 One beat or two?

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Write 1 or 2 under each. The first is done.



2 Fill the bar

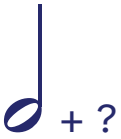
★★☆

Four beats in each bar. Write the missing note: crotchet or minim. The first is done.



minim

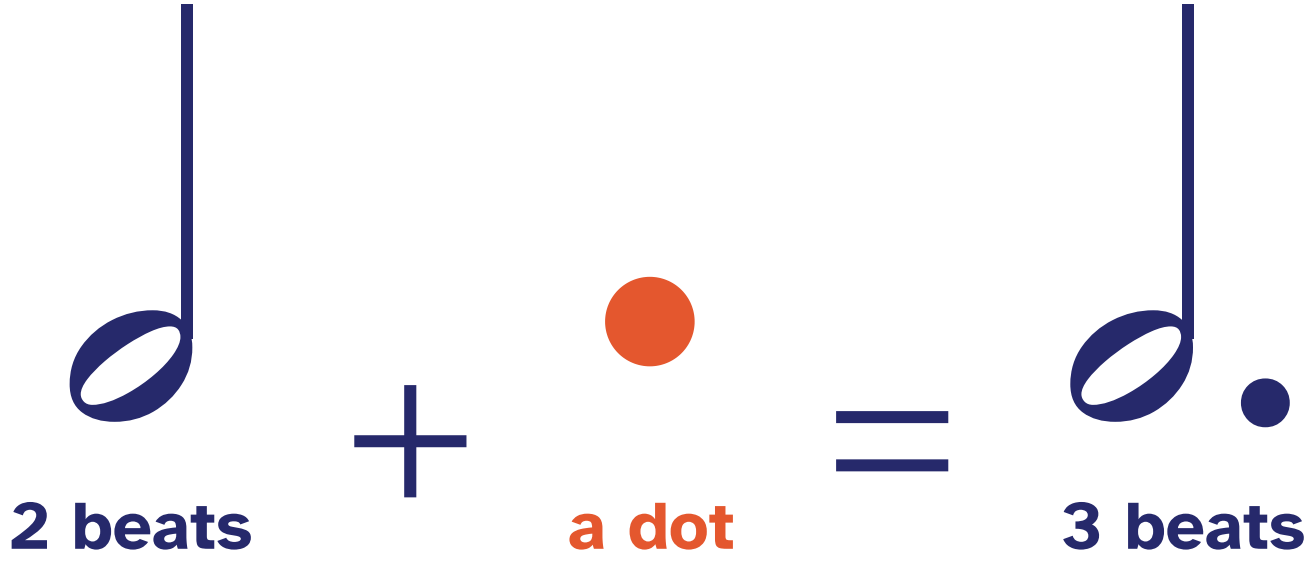




ROOM 7 · STEP 1 OF 3

Notes: three beats and four

SCAN TO LISTEN



A **dot** after a minim adds one more beat.

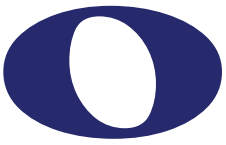
Two beats and one more: a **dotted minim** lasts **three beats**.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C and hold for 1 2 3. Lean in on beat 1.

ROOM 7 · STEP 2 OF 3

Notes: three beats and four



1 – 2 – 3 – 4



This is a **semibreve**: an empty head and no stem. It lasts **four beats**, a whole bar of four.

Press once, and listen until the sound has had all four beats.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C and hold for 1 2 3 4. Lift exactly when the next bar begins.

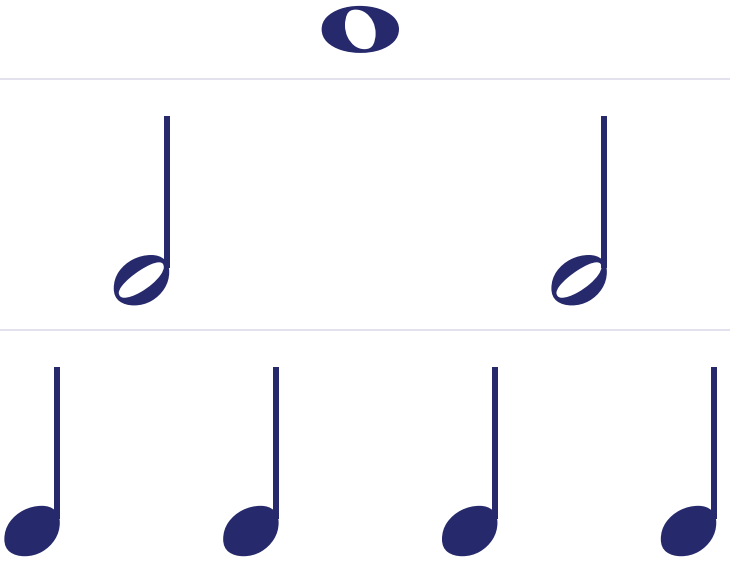
ROOM 7 · STEP 3 OF 3

Notes: three beats and four

1 semibreve

2 minims

4 crotchets





Now you know the family. Each note is **half** of the one above it.

One semibreve is as long as two minims, or four crotchets.

Try it at the piano

1. Play four crotchets on C. Then one semibreve, held for all four beats. The same length!

ROOM 7 · PRACTISE

Notes: three beats and four

1 Name and beats

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Fill in the table. The first row is done.

NOTE	NAME	BEATS
	semibreve	4
		
		
		

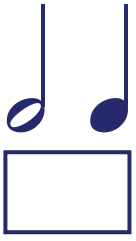
2 Three in a bar

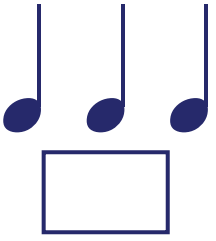
★★☆

Each bar has three beats. Count 1 2 3 and play each bar. Write how many notes it has. The first is done.



1





ROOM 8 · STEP 1 OF 2

Loud and soft

SCAN TO LISTEN



p soft ***f*** loud

Music can be **soft** or **loud**. The signs are Italian: ***p*** for *piano*, soft, and ***f*** for *forte*, loud.

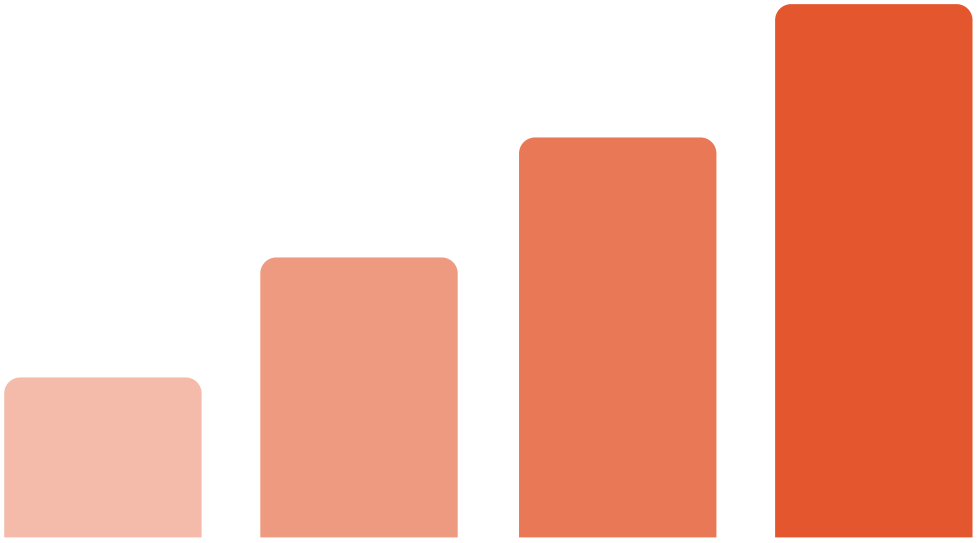
To play louder, let your arm feel heavy. Do not hit the key.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C softly, like a secret. Then play it loudly, like calling across a field.

ROOM 8 · STEP 2 OF 2

Loud and soft



p	*mp*	*mf*	*f*
soft	quite soft	quite loud	loud



In between come two more. The ***m*** is for *mezzo*, which means **half** or **medium**: ***mp*** is quite soft, ***mf*** is quite loud.

Soft does not mean slow, and loud does not mean fast. The beat stays the same.

Try it at the piano

1. Play C four times: p, mp, mf, f. Four steps, the same speed. ○

ROOM 8 · PRACTISE

Loud and soft

1 What does it mean?

★☆☆

Write soft, loud, quite soft or quite loud. The first is done.

SIGN	MEANS
p	soft
f	
mp	
mf	

2 Play it

★☆☆

Play C four times: p, mp, mf, f. Four steps, the same speed. Tick a circle each day.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

ROOM 9 · STEP 1 OF 1

Ear training

SCAN TO PLAY

1 **Low, middle or high?**

2 **Same clapping, or different?**

3 **Same tune, or different?**

4 **Which way did it go?**

5 **Find the note**



Listen first, then play. Good ears make good fingers.

Five listening games are waiting in the app. Scan the code and play one each day.

Try it at the piano

1 Before you play a note, sing it. Then play it and listen: were you right?

ROOM 9 · PRACTISE

Ear training

1 Floor, tummy or sky?

★☆☆

A grown-up plays one key: very low, in the middle, or very high. Eyes closed! Point to the floor, your tummy or the sky.

2 Copy-cat clap

★☆☆

A grown-up claps a short pattern. Clap it back exactly. Then swap: you clap, they copy.